



MONTHLY UPDATE

Ethiopia: monthly update, July 2026

Edition of 2026-08-04 · 24 systems and instruments tracked, 4 of them not held

Developments recorded from artefacts published between 2026-07-01 and 2026-08-04 – July 2026 carried forward to the date of issue, so the report holds the nightly catch to the day it was cut. Sections follow the status report.

Summary of the month

[Ethio Telecom's FY2025/26 figures](#) put it at 69% of all national identity registrations, at 60.6m mobile-money users moving about 11bn Birr a day, and at 90.1m subscribers on 99.8% coverage. A single vertically integrated state incumbent now supplies the identity enrolment, the payments rail and the network beneath both.

At the launch of a three-year plan, regional executives [told federal management](#) that the one-stop service platform is absorbing services that were never digitised, that two incompatible integration models have emerged, and that no legal framework compels an institution to digitise before joining.

The central bank widened its virtual-asset prohibition by clarification rather than by new rule. The payment-gateway sector continued to be taxed on an arithmetic error the same bank has admitted and corrected, with no effect on the assessment.

Infrastructure

Ethio Telecom and Huawei were reported on 15 and 17 July to be widening a network-equipment relationship into cloud, AI, cybersecurity, IoT, data-centre services and digital platforms for enterprises and small businesses, with mobile-money integration for payments and e-commerce. It is explicitly scoping rather than an executed agreement, and no value or term is disclosed. The vendor that supplies the radio network would supply the enterprise cloud and AI layer above it.

Alongside it, a separate data-centre track with Inspur and Shandong was reported on 16 July, and the same coverage records the device side — bank financing deals targeting up to two million smartphones a year to low-income citizens on instalment plans.

Nothing moved on the third-operator question, on satellite licensing, or on the fibre corridor whose binding agreement was February's news.

Digital public infrastructure

The identity programme supplied most of the month's movement: a [joint venture with Safaricom and a local partner](#) on 6 July to run mass registration across seven regions; a refugee-inclusion framework on 16 July making the credential central to a state-led model for 1.1m refugees and 2m internally displaced people; and, on 24 July, the operator's own disclosure that it accounts for 69% of all registrations, with more than 4m farmers enrolled through the agriculture ministry and more than 28,000 displaced people through humanitarian partners.

At the 24 July launch of a three-year strategic plan, its deputy director in the capital named premature integration as the year's main obstacle and its founding director general conceded the platform remains intertwined with decades-old institutional systems of undefined standards. The same meeting disclosed that a prime-ministerial board has approved a national data exchange platform . the interoperability layer the same meeting identified as missing.

Payments extended into utilities and tax. Prepaid electricity purchase entered the mobile-money super app on 29 July for smart-meter customers, and a digital tax-payment service for one regional revenue bureau launched on 28 July as the first of a planned series. AI service bundles from an Ethiopian firm went on sale inside the same app on 22 July, bought with mobile money and redeemed by SMS voucher.

Governance and regulation

On 23 July the central bank issued a [public notice](#) stating that use, sale, transfer, settlement and facilitation of virtual assets are prohibited unless expressly authorised, and that the prohibition was never confined to cryptocurrencies. No new regulation and no enforcement mechanism accompanied it: the instrument is a notice restating scope, not a rule.

On 25 July the [payment-gateway tax case](#) was set out in full. The central bank, compiling processing data for a revenue audit, conflated gross transaction volume with gateway revenue — restating one gateway's three-year throughput of ETB 32bn as ETB 143.9bn and taxing the difference at 30%, where gateways in fact earn about 2.5% commission. Corrected datasets issued by letter in April 2026 and verified by a governor's technical committee were not accepted; ETB 818m was swept from frozen accounts in May against a liability counsel puts at ETB 20–30m, with parallel sweeps against two other gateways, and the justice ministry declined to intervene on the ground that no administrative body can reverse a revenue decision.

Also in the month: founding membership of a Shanghai-headquartered intergovernmental AI body signed on 20 July, and a National Digital Transformation Council meeting on 30 July restating that the programme is to be judged on lives changed rather than systems deployed — a measurement claim with no published measure behind it.

Artificial intelligence and the technology sector

The FY2026/27 federal budget ratified on 7 July carries *Artificial Intelligence University Construction* as a single named capital project at ETB 5,000,000,000 — domestic money, appropriated rather than pledged, and large enough to dominate the year's digital total on its own. A national AI policy was adopted in 2024 and the AI institute has operated since 2020.

Nothing moved on the national AI policy itself, on the model-development side, or on which foundation models the country runs.

Inclusion, capacity and finance

Parliament [ratified a 2.34 trillion birr federal budget](#) for FY2026/27 on 7 July, up 21.3% on the year before, carrying ETB 9,049,102,733 of identifiable digital lines against ETB 3,754,558,918 the previous year and ETB 1,206,492,295 the year before that.

Two caveats the budget documents support. The FY2024/25 to FY2025/26 rise is mostly the birr float following the move to a floating exchange rate, not fiscal expansion. And the FY2026/27 total is dominated by the single AI university line, so the underlying operating envelope for digital government grew far less than the headline.

No execution data has been published for the whole of FY2025/26, and no audit is available for any year in scope — so a budget that has grown roughly sevenfold in nominal terms across three years cannot be checked against what was actually spent.

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